



and dark has created an emphasis on saunas and exercise, which help to keep people feeling fit and happy. From June 21 until December 22, four minutes of daylight are lost every day. The sun might not be seen at

all during midwinter, but when it appears in the summer, it is celebrated. Forests cover much of Finland and up until recently, many people held jobs in forestry. Finns today still respect nature and enjoy the scenery.



MIDSUMMER BONFIRES

Midsummer, or *Jubannus*, marks the summer solstice. It became a Christian feast although it was marked even before Christianity came to Finland. Today it is a celebration of nature. People go to the countryside, or decorate their towns with lilac and birch. At night they light *kokkos* (bonfires), which symbolize purity and ward off evil spirits. *Jubannus* also provides an occasion for people to fly the national flag.

A HEALTHY SWEAT

Although not a Finnish invention, the word “sauna” is Finnish, and steam baths have been a part of Finnish culture for over 1,000 years. There are 1.7 million saunas in Finland—that’s one for every three people.



1 Hot house

Almost every house has its own sauna, and minisaunas are even built inside apartments! Saunas are a great way to relax and socialize during the dark winters.



2 Heating up

In the steam room rocks are heated on a stove and then splashed with water to create steam. The point of a sauna is to induce sweat, and thereby open the skin’s pores.



3 Cooling down

From the steam room, bathers plunge into a pool of icy water or else roll in the snow. The sudden contrast is invigorating and refreshes both body and mind.



LAST DAY OF SCHOOL

Graduating from school in Finland calls for a big celebration. Those graduating are presented with their diplomas, red roses, and a distinctive white cap. After the formal ceremony at the school, families host parties for their graduating son or daughter.